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INDIA WILL RESIST AGGRESSION WITH ALL HER MIGHT

PRIME MINISTER'S INDEPENDENCE DAY SPEECH

New Delhi, Sravana 24, 1889
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The Prime Minister, Shrimati Indira Gandhi, has said that while India stands for peace and a peaceful solution of all problems, she will resist aggression on her borders with all her might. Speaking from the ramparts of the Red Fort on the 20th anniversary of India's Independence, she said that the jawans and the airmen were full of determination and courage. The nation's honour was safe in their hands. They would defend the territorial integrity of India with their lives. During her recent visits to forward areas, she had assured the jawans and the airmen that the entire nation was behind them.

The Prime Minister said that the people of India could not escape their responsibility. They too had to be prepared to make sacrifices. She added: "We stand for peace at home and abroad. Tensions are sometimes inevitable in the world. There are tensions even between brothers and sisters. All problems should be solved peacefully. That has been and continues to be India's endeavour."

Referring to drought and food shortages during the last one year, the Prime Minister said that the people had faced difficulties with courage and fortitude. Lakhs of lives had been saved. In the past too, the people of India had faced innumerable difficulties and had always overcome them. There was no room for despondency. She said the Government was determined

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to break the vicious circle of rising prices and the consequent demand for higher wages.

Referring to Centre-State relations, the Prime Minister said that it had been the Central Government's constant endeavour to extend the fullest cooperation to all States. The charge of discrimination against any was baseless. The Centre wanted an equitable sharing of food and other resources.

Following is a free translation of the Prime Minister's speech:

For the second successive year, I have unfurled the National Flag on the Red Fort. You will recall that last year we were drenched in rain on this occasion and there were earth tremors. The tremors were a warning of the coming difficulties. While on this day last year, we stood in rain there was a severe drought in the many parts of the country during the year. The people were faced with immense difficulties. Today at this time, there is no rain here but India is having an excellent monsoon. Let us hope that we have the required rainfall and the country will take a new turn. Let us hope there will no more drought and food shortages. Let us hope that we will begin a new life.

The people in drought-affected areas have faced innumerable difficulties with great courage and fortitude. This is not surprising. Our people have always been known to overcome difficulties. Our people have gone through difficult times in the past; they have faced many aggressions.

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Why has the Red Fort been chosen for this ceremony? Because in a way it is the door-step of India. The banner freedom was raised from here on many occasions. When the battle of freedom was fought and the country was partitione there were riots, the message of unity and independence wer from the Red Fort.

The people of India have survived many crises. Today there is a feeling of despondency in the country. Only a fe days ago, we observed the 25th anniversary of the Quit India Movement. Twentyfive years ago there was gloom in the world The world was in the midst of World War II. At that time Ga ji gave us the 'do or die' message to achieve deliverance fr foreign rule. There was not a ray of hope of India becoming free but in a short period of five years our dream came true. From this we have to learn the lesson that the gloom is not perpetual. The darkness will end soon and the dawn is near. will soon overcome our difficulties. We need courage and determination to overcome difficulties.

During the last 20 years, much has happened. Perhaps we have achieved much more. Nevertheless our achievements are ma A new generation is born in India. It is not aware that India lived in slavery. It is not aware of our freedom struggle. It is not aware that the poor and hungry masses of India fought th mighty battle of freedom and won it.

Some voices are raised that there has been no improvement in the lot of the Indian people. Publicity is given to it in India and abroad. But if we look around we will find that

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while milk, sugar and other articles of daily necessity were cheaper in the past, there were no avenues of progress for the people. There were no facilities for the education of children. The living condition of farmers and the other rural folk was not satisfactory. Their children did not attend school. They did not own bicycles. The spirit of enterprise was lacking. We have definitely made progress during the last 20 years. Maybe the pace of progress has not been fast enough but it has been continuous.

The rural folk are aware of their difficulty of having to swim across swollen rivers and rivulets during the monsoon. The fast flowing current poses dangers. India is in a somewhat similar situation. I have no doubt that given courage and determination, the people of India will be able to swim across the deep waters. We cannot afford to look back; we cannot afford to wait even for a single second. We must continue our march towards progress. We must swim across the swollen river of difficulties. Once we have swum across the river, our progress will be easier.

Violence has no place in India. We must fight communalism, linguism and casteism if we have to make speedier progress. Regionalism also poses a danger. One can understand the desire of every State to make progress but no individual or State can make progress in isolation. We must keep the picture of a united India before us all the time. We have faced many challenges and many difficulties in the past. We have always overcome them. Today we are faced with food shortages, not in one State,

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but in many parts of the country. Food shortages have created a new problem and new doubts in our minds. We may recall that when India became free, we were assailed with doubts whether we would be able to form a Government and maintain the unity of the country. After the partition of the country, there was aggression on Kashmir. Later Gandhiji was assassinated. Our great leaders left us one by one. However, the people of India gained strength side by side. The vast mass of people living in the length and breadth of India are the nation's real strength.

We have undoubtedly made progress in the economic sphere. We have set up new industries. We have increased our agricultural production. We have to maintain the rate of progress in the agricultural and industrial fields.

We have made every effort to reach foodgrains to deficit areas. You are aware that West Bengal, Kerala, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and many other parts of the country are faced with food shortages. Through the efforts of the Government and non-official organisations, the needs of the people were met to some extent. The coming two or three months are full of difficulties. I would like to congratulate the people of these States for the courage with which they faced difficulties. They have upheld the honour of India. They have shown that a free nation is capable of overcoming difficulties.

The people of India are faced with many other problems. There is the problem of rising prices. There is a demand for higher wages. This problem is not confined to India. The whole world is faced with the problem of rising prices and the demand for higher

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wages. It is a vicious circle of rising prices, higher rents, higher wages and again higher prices. It is our endeavour to break this vicious circle. We want to stabilize prices. We have all to cooperate to solve this problem. We have to make sacrifices. We should restrict our purchases of consumer goods. It is not an easy problem. The poorer sections of the community are the worst suffers. I have the greatest sympathy for them. We have to find ways and means of solving this problem.

I know that everyone wants an increase in his wages. People are also worried that they can buy very little even with increased wages. We have to find a solution to the problem of people's needs. We have limited resources. We have to consider ways and means of augmenting our resources. If we can increase our resources by suffering hardship, we should not hesitate to do so. Then our difficulties will end soon. Unless we increase our resources, we will only be postponing our hardship.

Our Constitution envisages the formation of Governments by different parties in different States. Today we have governments of different complexions. They have freedom to follow their own path. It has always been our endeavour to extend the fullest cooperation to them. Sometimes, perhaps in anger, or perhaps because of their helplessness in the face of difficulties, the States accuse us of discriminatory treatment. The charge of discrimination is absolutely baseless. India is one nation. We treat all citizens equally. All States are equal in our eyes. It is our endeavour to ensure equitable distribution of food and other resources. We want to remove the difficulties of all. But

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as our resources are limited, we can only share what we have. I do hope that the people will appreciate our difficulty and co-operate with us.

We have taken up many projects for the development of the country. We have spread education. Progress in such fields as women's welfare, development of communications and industrialisation has brought many changes. We have opened up new vistas of progress. But as we progress in new fields, new difficulties arise. All sections of community are faced with difficulties. Unrest is a world phenomenon, whether it is among students or other sections. There are the problems of race, language or other similar problems facing various countries. We should not magnify our difficulties.

Two years ago, our leaders put forward a proposal that education upto the University level should be in the mother-tongue so that the benefits of education could reach everyone and the talents of the people could find a natural outlet. Can we achieve this? Even a good proposal sometimes contains the seeds of danger. It is feared that this proposal might encourage separatism. This proposal could prove beneficial if there is a link language which can bind the people together and thus help maint national unity. Similarly, there is need to maintain link with the world. In the present-day world, we cannot afford to live in isolation. It will prove harmful to our interests. Therefore, there should be three languages - regional language, national language and international language. We have to keep in view the difficulties of the people in the matter of language.

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We have to consider how difficulties of the people in various parts could be minimised and how they could be helped in every possible way. No one should have the feeling that something is being thrust on him, or impediments are being put in his path.

Sometimes we think that a particular view is beneficial to the people at large. But there are people holding other views. In this matter we have to carry the people with us. We cannot ignore the views of others. We have to find a solution which is acceptable to all, which does not weaken our democratic structure or our national unity. The question of language generates emotion and anger. If a proper solution is found, language can become a force for national unity and national progress.

Regional tendencies have been on the increase. The people of each State think that if development schemes are implemented in that particular State, India would make rapid progress. Unfortunately, our resources are limited. We have to determine an order of priority for different development schemes. We must look upon all States as our own. There is no need to feel upset if a development scheme is implemented in another State. We should be patient. Gradually, all development schemes will be implemented. We should draw inspiration from our past when we overcame innumerable difficulties.

We need peace for our progress. We want peace at home and abroad. We stand for world peace. There are tensions sometimes. All kinds of questions arise. There are tensions even in a family, between brothers and sisters. We have always stood for peaceful --

peaceful solution of all questions. It has always been and continues to be our endeavour that all questions should be solved through peaceful means. But if there is aggression on our borders, we will meet it with all our might. A few days ago, I visited some forward areas. Our officers and jawans are guarding our borders with courage. They are not deterred by adverse weather conditions. I have seen them guard the snowy mountains. I assured them that the entire nation is behind them. I conveyed to them the good wishes of the Government and people of India. I have full confidence that the honour of India is safe in the hands of our Armed Forces. Let us not forget that we have a responsibility too. Our officers and jawans are bearing hardship and are prepared to sacrifice their lives to protect the territorial integrity of India. We should also be ready to bear hardship and make sacrifices. We should keep in view our objectives.

What is socialism? There are differing definitions. A simple definition of socialism is that poverty should be eradicated; disparities between the rich and the poor should be reduced; the backward people - be they Harijans, Adivasies or the hill people - should have equal opportunities to make progress; and there should be equal distribution of national resources. This is our socialism and this is our goal. We want to achieve this goal rapidly.

Sons and daughters of India - be you workers or kisans, businessmen or industrialists, teachers or students, writers or artists - you are all inhabitants of this great country. You should not forget this even for a moment. Through your veins

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runs the blood of heroes and great men. Let diffidence give way to confidence; let despair give way to hope. We will the be able to build a strong nation; we will then be able to rai the structure of a beautiful Bharat. We are capable of doing We have embarked on an exciting venture. We shall face every difficulty - be it war or famine - with courage and determina ion. We shall not let the Nation go under.

My countrymen, join me with all your heart in raising th national slogan of Jai Hind. Let the slogan echo all over. L it be a symbol of our determination, of our enthusiasm, of our confidence and of our national strength. Let the slogan guide us towards national progress.

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